

>> strength stretch

You don't need to be a contortionist to master this final sequence. Use your body control to guide you into these more advanced movements. Regard it as your ultimate goal. Even beginners can discover how much control they need to exert, whether they are trying to balance in a precarious pose or performing the simplest stretch.

Strength by definition means grounding and control. See this sequence as one feat of strength after another in an Olympic trial. Close up, you can see the suppleness of an athlete's body, and in action you can see the litheness of their motions. Think of all the hours of preparation Olympic athletes must endure to reach their final goal. In this sequence, look at each exercise as a goal in and of itself. The trick is to break each exercise down by starting small and gradually building to a larger and steadier range of motion. Remember that achieving a general level of fitness takes about two months of practice, and developing a split may take more like six months, depending on how naturally flexible you are. The recipe for Olympic development is to stress the body, then to rest it. Be wise and give your body a good rest after practicing this sequence. The poses and movements here move toward a crescendo that primes you for success.

The exercises

Set the tone for strength by standing tall in the Butterfly stretch and the Upper side bend. Feel your upper body moving against the lower body, as if your lower body were rooted and anchored, like a great oak tree. The series of squats that follows coordinates the strength and suppleness of the spine with the suppleness of the legs. Get more benefit by opening your knees as wide as you can in the Wide squat twist and in the

>> tips for strength stretch

- **Think of your spine** and legs grounded like the trunk and roots of a great oak tree.
- **Remember, you're not failing** if you need to use props and smaller positions to help you get familiar with the exercises.
- **Find your "pelvic diaphragm"**, and keep looking for ways to coordinate your inner muscle strength as you work with larger movements.
- **Always be careful** with large stretches of the neck. Never pull on the head.

Deep squat. These squats also provide a great opportunity to strengthen the "pelvic diaphragm"—the parachute-like muscle layer that lies at the bottom of the torso.

As you perform the next exercise, the Neck stretch, bear in mind that you are now coordinating the "neck diaphragm"—the parachute-like muscle and soft tissue layers defining the top of the rib cage—with the pelvic diaphragm. So this sequence works on more levels than meet the eye. It is the ultimate in strength and control. Become willing to acquire the ability to coordinate deep muscles